

college,” he replied, “I’m going to be rich.”

“If you don’t graduate from college, you won’t get a good job,” I responded with a tinge of panic and motherly concern. “And if you don’t have a good job, how do you plan to get rich?”

My son smirked and slowly shook his head with mild boredom. We have had this talk many times before. He lowered his head and rolled his eyes. My words of motherly wisdom were falling on deaf ears once again.

Though smart and strong-willed, he has always been a polite and respectful young man.

“Mom,” he began. It was my turn to be lectured. “Get with the times! Look around; the richest people didn’t get rich because of their educations. Look at Michael Jordan and Madonna. Even Bill Gates, who dropped out of Harvard, founded Microsoft; he is now the richest man in America, and he’s still in his 30s. There is a baseball pitcher who makes more than \$4 million a year even though he has been labeled ‘mentally challenged.’ ”

There was a long silence between us. It was dawning on me that I was giving my son the same advice my parents had given me. The world around us has changed, but the advice hasn’t.

Getting a good education and making good grades no longer ensures success, and nobody seems to have noticed, except our children.

“Mom,” he continued, “I don’t want to work as hard as you and dad do. You make a lot of money, and we live in a huge house with lots of toys. If I follow your advice, I’ll wind up like you, working harder and harder only to pay more taxes and wind up in debt. There is no job security anymore; I know all about downsizing and rightsizing. I also know that college graduates today earn less than you did when you graduated. Look at doctors. They don’t make nearly as much money as they used to. I know I can’t rely on Social Security or company pensions for retirement. I need new answers.”

He was right. He needed new answers, and so did I. My parents’ advice may have worked for people born before 1945, but it may be disastrous for those of us born into a rapidly changing world. No longer can I simply say to my children,

“Go to school, get good grades, and look for a safe, secure job.”

I knew I had to look for new ways to guide my children’s education.

As a mother as well as an accountant, I have been concerned by the lack of financial education our children receive in school. Many of today’s youth have credit cards before they leave high school, yet